

THE COMPLETE DBT SKILLS WORKBOOK

All 4 Modules in One Book

Mindfulness | Distress Tolerance
Emotion Regulation | Interpersonal Effectiveness

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This workbook is for educational purposes and personal growth.

It is not a replacement for professional DBT therapy.

WHAT IS DBT?

Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) was developed by Dr. Marsha Linehan.
It combines cognitive-behavioral techniques with mindfulness practices.

DBT teaches four core skill sets:

1. MINDFULNESS - Being present and aware without judgment
2. DISTRESS TOLERANCE - Surviving crisis without making it worse
3. EMOTION REGULATION - Understanding and managing emotions
4. INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS - Getting needs met in relationships

The Dialectic: Two things can be true at the same time.

- I am doing my best AND I can do better.
- I can accept myself AND want to change.
- This is painful AND I can cope with it.

How to use this workbook:

- Work through each module in order or as directed by your therapist
- Practice skills daily, not just during crisis
- Use the diary cards to track your progress
- Be patient with yourself - skills take time to master

MODULE 1: MINDFULNESS

WISE MIND

Reasonable Mind: logical, factual, task-focused

Emotion Mind: feelings-driven, reactive, hot

Wise Mind: the overlap - intuition + logic

Exercise: Think of a recent decision.

What did Reasonable Mind say?

What did Emotion Mind say?

What does Wise Mind say?

MODULE 1: MINDFULNESS

OBSERVE

Notice without getting caught up in the experience.

Just notice. Don't push away or hold on.

Exercise: Set a timer for 3 minutes.

Observe your breath without changing it.

What did you notice?

What pulled your attention away?

How many times did you return to observing?

MODULE 1: MINDFULNESS

DESCRIBE

Put words on the experience. Label what you observe.

Stick to facts - no interpretations.

Exercise: Describe your current emotional state using ONLY facts:

Body sensations:

Thoughts present:

Urges:

Label the emotion:

MODULE 1: MINDFULNESS

PARTICIPATE

Throw yourself completely into the current activity.

Become one with what you are doing.

Exercise: Choose an activity today to fully participate in:

Activity chosen:

How long did you maintain full presence?

What brought you back when you drifted?

How did it feel to be fully present?

MODULE 1: MINDFULNESS

NON-JUDGMENTAL STANCE

See but don't evaluate. Take a non-judgmental stance.

Replace judgments with facts.

Judgmental thought:

Rewritten without judgment:

Judgmental thought:

Rewritten without judgment:

Judgmental thought:

Rewritten without judgment:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

TIPP - Change Body Chemistry

T - Temperature: Cold water on face (dive reflex)

I - Intense Exercise: 20 min to reduce emotional arousal

P - Paced Breathing: exhale longer than inhale

P - Progressive Relaxation: tense & release muscles

My TIPP plan:

When distress is at 7+, I will:

Cold items I keep available:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

STOP SKILL

S - Stop. Don't react. Freeze.

T - Take a step back. Breathe.

O - Observe. What's happening inside and outside?

P - Proceed mindfully. Act with awareness.

Recent situation I could have used STOP:

What happened instead:

How STOP could have changed the outcome:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

PROS AND CONS

Crisis urge I'm having:

ACTING on urge - PROS:

ACTING on urge - CONS:

NOT acting on urge - PROS:

NOT acting on urge - CONS:

My decision:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

SELF-SOOTHE WITH 5 SENSES

Vision - What I can look at:

Hearing - What I can listen to:

Smell - What scents comfort me:

Taste - What flavors help:

Touch - What textures soothe:

My personalized self-soothe kit:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

IMPROVE THE MOMENT

I - Imagery (safe place visualization)

M - Meaning (find purpose in pain)

P - Prayer/meditation

R - Relaxation

O - One thing in the moment

V - Vacation (brief mental escape)

E - Encouragement (self-talk)

My go-to IMPROVE skills:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE

What I'm resisting accepting:

Evidence it IS reality:

Causes that led to this:

Can I change this? (yes/no):

What life is worth living looks like even with this:

Acceptance statement: I accept that _____

even though I don't like it or approve of it.

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

TURNING THE MIND

Acceptance is not a one-time choice - it must be made again and again.

Situation requiring acceptance:

Times today I turned AWAY from acceptance:

What pulled me away:

My commitment to turn back:

Reminder I can post where I'll see it:

MODULE 2: DISTRESS TOLERANCE

WILLINGNESS VS. WILLFULNESS

Willingness: doing what is needed, being open

Willfulness: refusing to accept, sitting on hands, giving up

Where am I being willful?

What would willingness look like?

One willing action I can take today:

What's blocking my willingness?

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

NAMING EMOTIONS

What am I feeling right now?

Primary emotion:

Secondary emotion (what came after):

Body sensation:

Intensity (0-10):

Urge that comes with this emotion:

Is this emotion justified by the facts?

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

EMOTION MYTHS

Myth: There is a right way to feel in every situation.

Reality:

Myth: Letting others know I am feeling bad is weakness.

Reality:

Myth: Negative feelings are bad and destructive.

Reality:

Myth: Being emotional means being out of control.

Reality:

My personal emotion myth:

The truth:

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

OPPOSITE ACTION

Emotion I want to change:

Is it justified by the facts? (yes/no):

Action urge that goes with this emotion:

OPPOSITE action:

Did I act opposite ALL THE WAY?

Result:

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

ABC PLEASE

A - Accumulate positives (short-term):

A - Accumulate positives (long-term goals):

B - Build mastery (what did I do well?):

C - Cope ahead (upcoming difficult situation):

Plan:

PL - treat Physical illness

E - balanced Eating

A - avoid mood-Altering substances

S - balanced Sleep

E - get Exercise

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

BUILDING MASTERY

Do one thing each day to feel competent and in control.

Day 1 mastery activity:

Day 2:

Day 3:

Day 4:

Day 5:

Day 6:

Day 7:

How did building mastery affect my mood?

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

COPE AHEAD

Describe the situation:

Emotions/actions I want to AVOID:

Skills I will use:

Step-by-step plan:

1.

2.

3.

Potential obstacles:

How I'll handle obstacles:

Rehearsal: I visualized this (date):

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

CHECK THE FACTS

Emotion:

_____ Intensity (0-10): ____

Prompting event (facts only):

My interpretation:

Other possible interpretations:

Am I assuming a threat?

What's the actual probability?

If it happens, can I cope?

Does my emotion fit the FACTS?

MODULE 3: EMOTION REGULATION

EMOTION REGULATION PLAN

My most problematic emotion:

Triggers:

Early warning signs:

Skills that work for this emotion:

People who can help:

Self-care that prevents this emotion:

My commitment:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

DEAR MAN - Getting What You Want

D - Describe the situation (facts only)

E - Express how you feel (I statements)

A - Assert what you need (ask clearly)

R - Reinforce (explain benefits to them)

M - Mindful (stay on topic, broken record)

A - Appear confident (eye contact, tone)

N - Negotiate (be willing to give to get)

Situation:

My DEAR MAN script:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

GIVE - Keeping the Relationship

G - Gentle (no attacks, threats, or judging)

I - Interested (listen, appear interested)

V - Validate (acknowledge their feelings)

E - Easy manner (smile, be light, humor)

Person:

How I will be Gentle:

How I will show Interest:

How I will Validate:

How I will keep it Easy:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

FAST - Keeping Self-Respect

F - Fair (be fair to yourself AND others)

A - Apologies (no over-apologizing)

S - Stick to values (don't sell out)

T - Truthful (no lying, no helplessness act)

Value at stake:

What I will NOT apologize for:

Where I am being unfair to myself:

Truth I need to tell:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

PRIORITIES - What Matters Most?

In this interaction, what matters MOST?

☐ Getting what I want (DEAR MAN focus)

☐ Keeping the relationship (GIVE focus)

☐ Keeping my self-respect (FAST focus)

Why this is my priority:

What I'm willing to sacrifice:

What I'm NOT willing to sacrifice:

Ideal outcome:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

SAYING NO

Saying no is not selfish - it is self-respecting.

Request I need to decline:

Why I'm saying no:

My NO script:

If they push back, I will:

I have a right to say no because:

Broken record technique: repeat your no calmly and briefly.

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

BUILDING RELATIONSHIPS

Relationships need investment. What am I investing?

Relationship I want to strengthen:

What they need from me:

What I need from them:

One thing I can do this week:

Barriers to connection:

Skills I need to use:

My relationship maintenance plan:

Daily:

Weekly:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

INTERPERSONAL PATTERNS

My common patterns in relationships:

Pattern 1:

How it hurts me:

Skill to change it:

Pattern 2:

How it hurts me:

Skill to change it:

Pattern 3:

How it hurts me:

Skill to change it:

MODULE 4: INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS

VALIDATION

6 Levels of Validation:

1. Pay attention (be present)
2. Reflect back (repeat what they said)
3. Mind-read (guess their feelings)
4. Understand causes (makes sense given history)
5. Acknowledge the valid (find kernel of truth)
6. Radical genuineness (treat as equal)

Person I want to validate better:

Level I usually reach:

Level I want to practice:

How I will practice:

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 1

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 2

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 3

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 4

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 5

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 6

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 7

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 8

Rate each 0-5 (0=not at all, 5=extremely)

Day	Joy	Sad	Anger	Shame	Fear	Urges	Skills Used
Mon	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Tue	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Wed	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Thu	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Fri	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sat	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____
Sun	—	—	—	—	—	—	_____

Skills practiced this week:

☐ Mindfulness ☐ Distress Tolerance ☐ Emotion Regulation ☐ Interpersonal

Highest distress level (0-10): ____ Skills used in crisis: _____

Wise Mind moments: _____

MY CRISIS SURVIVAL PLAN

Warning signs that a crisis is building:

My distress tolerance skills (in order of use):

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

People I can call for support:

1.

 Phone:

2.

 Phone:

3.

 Phone:

Professional resources:

Therapist:

 Phone:

Crisis line: 988

Emergency: 911

Reasons to stay alive / things worth living for:

1.

2.

3.

SKILLS I'VE MASTERED

Check off skills as you master them:

MINDFULNESS

- ☐ Wise Mind
- ☐ Observe
- ☐ Describe
- ☐ Participate
- ☐ Non-judgmental

DISTRESS TOLERANCE

- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ STOP
- ☐ Pros/Cons
- ☐ Self-Soothe
- ☐ IMPROVE
- ☐ Radical Acceptance

EMOTION REGULATION

- ☐ Naming Emotions
- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ ABC PLEASE
- ☐ Check the Facts
- ☐ Cope Ahead

INTERPERSONAL

- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ GIVE
- ☐ FAST
- ☐ Saying No
- ☐ Validation

MY DBT JOURNEY REFLECTION

When I started DBT, I was:

The hardest module for me was:

Because:

The skill that changed my life:

How it changed things:

My biggest growth:

What I want to keep working on:

My commitment to myself:
